



How To Crush Your US College Application

*by building the perfect
personal profile*



A CRIMSON EDUCATION PUBLICATION

Your application has been accepted.

Imagine this. You're opening a letter from your dream college. Think of the anticipation, the anxiety, the excitement. Now imagine it says, "Congratulations. You're in."

This isn't an unrealistic goal for you. Yes, getting accepted into top US universities is becoming more competitive and more difficult every year. But, there is a surefire way of getting the attention of admissions officers.

And guess what? It isn't your grades alone. You could get a perfect SAT score and excellent grades and it won't be a guarantee that you will be accepted to a top university.

Grades are important, but unless you win a Millennium Prize for mathematics - they're only a benchmark. They aren't your golden ticket.

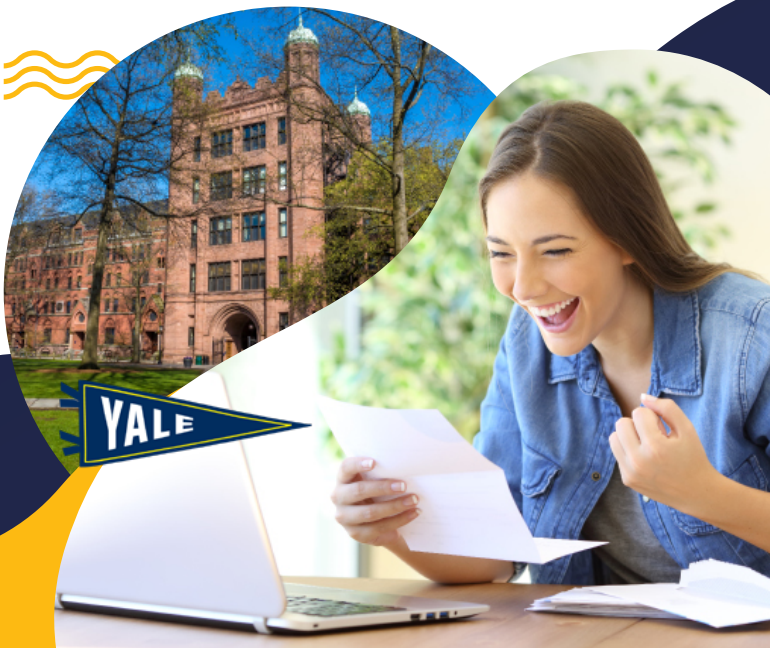
You need to be different. You need to be passionate, interesting, and exciting. You need to be an obvious contributor.



And how do you do that?

One of the ways to get accepted is to demonstrate your ability to impact others outside of the classroom.

By the end of this eBook, you're going to be equipped with the tools to build and exemplify your excellent extracurricular and leadership skills, make your application stand out, and make your extracurricular profile pop!





Getting in is getting more difficult

Now more than ever, more students are applying to the world's best universities.

In recent years, many students with perfect 1600 SAT scores have actually been rejected by Stanford — evidence that good scores alone are not enough to gain you admission.

Further, the number of applications to the eight Ivy League universities almost doubled in the past decade. In fact, in 1999–2000, Ivy League schools received 121,948 applications – and they rejected 80% of them. More recently, the Ivy League class of 2023 had 311,948 applicants, and just 21,168 were accepted. That's an acceptance rate of a only 6.72%.



Harvard Admissions Statistics - Class of 2023

43,330
applicants,
with...

1950
students
accepted =

4.5%
admission
rate

HARVARD

The nation's best schools have the luxury of hand selecting the world's best students. They can decide between a first-chair cellist with a 1550 SAT, and a state basketball player with a 1450 SAT, both of whom were school captains.

These days even the most talented of students are failing to make the cut.

In fact, these schools' selection lists are so long, they rarely have under-qualified applications. It is typical for every applicant to be a strong student. Everyone who applies has strong academics.

But there is light at the end of the tunnel. You just need to know how to shine in the cluttered application environment and know what admissions officers are looking for in each application.

Whether you dream of living and learning near New York City or being a part of a sports team in sunny California, your dreams are achievable. Make your application stand out to admissions officers by improving both your academics and extracurriculars under the guidance of a personalized Crimson team!



The stuff you really need to know

- A perfect SAT score doesn't mean you'll get into your dream school.
- A growing number of applicants and a stagnant number of seats available at top universities means the competition for admissions is getting tougher.
- Achieving your dreams is not only your priority, but ours as well. We will teach you what you need to know in order to make your application stand out from the other thousands submitted.



How this eBook was built



Drawing knowledge from our experienced team here at Crimson (from former admissions officers to this cycle's most successful applicants), we've built this guide to share our insights to help you create a competitive application to your dream school!

The Crimson team has helped students to broaden their horizons and open their minds to schools they never thought were possible - all because they were given the tools and expert advice key to building the perfect application for you.

Throughout this eBook, you will see a lot of references to the Ivy League schools; however, the information contained in this eBook is not specific to these schools. These universities are used as a benchmarks – they have the highest number of applications and traditionally low acceptance rates.

What the top universities are looking for

Step 1

Context and Theory

Well-lopsided vs. well-rounded candidate: which do universities prefer?

How do admissions officers separate great students from those who actually get in?

What does well-lopsided mean?

Think of a well-lopsided student as one who focuses on the two strokes in the letter 'T'. Horizontally they collaborate across disciplines and express empathy too those around them. While vertically they have depth in one particular area which aligns with their key personal passions.



In short a well-lopsided student is one who:

- Can do everything expected of them in the classroom and on campus (horizontal)
- Has an in-depth passion or skill that goes far deeper than their peers (vertical)

Essentially, these are students who possess a combination of intelligence, creativity, empathy, and initiative, while illustrating authentic, passionate interest in an area special to their personality.

Meet Tanya.

She is an excellent student; she gets good grades, participates in two or three major activities that exemplify her passions and interests, and she demonstrates empathy and compassion for her community and family.

But her major and most exciting feature is that she is a dancer. Tanya has been dancing since she was three and performs at a nationally recognized level.

Tanya is well-lopsided.



Well-lopsided students differ from those who are considered “well-rounded”. It’s a very important distinction. Everyone can present themselves as well-rounded in an application – balanced extracurricular activities, good grades, and some leadership activity.

But while well-roundedness is appreciated, it doesn’t showcase a student’s ability to pursue, in depth, interests and passions that are particularly important to them.

For example, meet Charlie.

Charlie is very involved in the school’s athletics team; he has good grades and has joined a few extracurricular activities in his final year of study, such as Model United Nations. Charlie will probably be elected president of the student body council.

He’s put together an application essay that reads well and everyone who meets him says he’s fun, friendly, and vibrant. Charlie’s classmates think he is a shoo-in for his preferred colleges. But unfortunately they may be wrong.

To an admissions officer Charlie may be a strong maybe - but not a shoo-in by any means. He is well-rounded, but his profile doesn’t show depth in any one particular area.





Some top universities show preference to particular types of students. For example, Stanford University is known for its preference for students who are passionate about technology and entrepreneurship.

To the untrained eye, Charlie looks like a glowing candidate on paper, but when you dig into his application he's not much different to any other prospective student. This makes his application that much easier to move to the rejection or waitlist pile as he joins a multitude of applicants just like him.

While Charlie is a great student, we don't know what makes him special, which also means we don't know exactly what he will bring to campus that is unique and different to everyone else.

As for his Model UN experience; how was it important to him, what did he take away from it, how did he expand on what was learned from it and make a difference beyond?

If none of these things are clear, unfortunately for Charlie, this means he will not be accepted to the universities that might seem at first glance 'sure things'.

Now, meet Sachin.

Sachin isn't on the athletics team, in fact, he is not great at sports in general. His grades are decent, but he is getting tutoring to improve his academic standing and is showing real progress.

He is also trying one new extracurricular activity this year – debating. It makes him dreadfully nervous, but his school didn't have a team and he thought it needed one!

And book club? Sachin founded a book club. He's the president. He organised a book drive in the local community to improve the school's library catalogue. He and his fellow book club enthusiasts go to the local shelter to read to disadvantaged community members once every month. Sachin loves book club. It's his baby.

Sachin is A-grade acceptance letter material. But why is Sachin better than Charlie?

Mainly because, outside of academics, Sachin shows passion through his book club, he shows initiative with starting the debate team and he's ethically and socially aware, convincing his peers to show empathy and help the disadvantaged.

If an admissions officer picks up both Sachin and Charlie's application, nine times out of ten they pick Sachin.



Whether it's book club, music, chess, or participating in a Model United Nations, it does not matter. Admissions officers are looking for who you are and what makes you different.

How do you show that you are different? By demonstrating PIE: **Passion, Initiative, and Empathy.**

The major change in college applications

Recently the Making Caring Common Project from the Harvard Graduate School of Education published a report called: "Turning the Tide: Inspiring Concern for Others and the Common Good Through College Admissions".

This report has reshaped the admissions process and what is considered important in a good application. More than 50 top ranked US universities participated. It is advisable to read the report; however, the key elements relevant here are:

- That applicants demonstrate **meaningful contributions toward people, community service, and engagement with the public good**
- **The assessment of students' ethical engagement with others**, and contributions to various family and community groups across race, culture, and class
- **The redefinition of achievement**, which reduces excessive achievement pressure while levelling the playing field economically.

Basically, outstanding personal achievement is subjective; meaningful and ethical contributions to the community and towards the good of others is what matters.



Step Two

How to show **you're well-lopsided**

Quality over quantity

Want to know how most people sabotage their applications? By thinking well-lopsided means throwing in a bunch of extracurriculars on their application, saying leadership a few times, and bang! They're done!

But unfortunately the university admissions process does not work that way. In fact, admissions officers can tell when students are stockpiling their applications with extracurriculars simply so that can 'get in'.

Admissions officers want a sense of your own special personal narrative. They don't want you to brag but demonstrate why your passions are important to you, and how you use them to make a difference.

- + They want to see someone who has done meaningful, sustained community service.
- + They want to see that you can work in a group and solve a community's problems.
- + They want to see someone who contributes to their own family.



The most important thing to remember is that there is no magic formula. Your story is unique and you need to tell it. At Crimson it is our job to help you do that in the most effective way. We can provide you with the framework of what admissions officers are looking for, but it is your talents and efforts that will make them sit up and take notice.

With that in mind, here are our recommendations:

You should aim for 2–3 main activities.

These activities should all have a cohesive theme – an underlying commonality that exemplifies you. For example:



You want bullying to end in school. So, all your extracurriculars demonstrate that.



You want a liberal arts education to learn more about other cultures.



You organize forums at school and participate in community service to help the disadvantaged.





Through activities like these, you will be able to demonstrate your passions.

Admissions officers want to see that you are in touch with your community and are aiming to ethically improve the community in an inclusive way.

For example, you could start with an anti-bullying campaign at school, raising awareness and bringing in people from different backgrounds and cultures to voice their issues.

Another idea, if you spend a lot of time with your family, or have a part time job, is to find a way to innovate within those activities. Find a way to organize your family's schedule better, or develop a new process to speed up efficiency at work.

These innovations demonstrate your ability to make positive change within an existing organization or community - otherwise known as intrapreneurship!



The point is, you are a good person trying to improve the world, and an education at your preferred college will help you make an even bigger and better impact.

All these activities show that you live your life using the PIE principle.



Key Takeaways

- Target two or three main activities
- Have a cohesive theme throughout your extracurriculars.
- Don't overdo extracurriculars. Think quality over quantity.

Step Three

Choosing The Right Extracurriculars

Picking a winner - or three

So how does a student begin? Start a club? Run a campaign? Organize a competition?

As we've said before, the key is authenticity – activities based around genuine interests and passions will be most effective.

Think about what really excites you and build this passion into something truly substantial that makes a difference in the wider community.

Following these three steps will help:

- Make a list of **everything you love to do.**
- Go through the list and **identify everything that could be used to enhance others' lives.**
- **Identify mentors and supporters.**





The three safest extracurriculars for any college application

Still struggling to decide what to choose or what will get you noticed?

Then you need to get the right blend. This isn't a definitive list, but a rule of thumb. You need to show you can take initiative and improve the community across a variety of fields.

So, your extracurriculars can include:



Career Activities



Community activities



Personal Activities



First, the career activity

This extracurricular is related to what you hope to study in college and shows the admissions teams that you are extremely excited about studying the major you have in your sights.

Schools want to admit students who are hard-working and passionate about their field. You need to show that your field isn't just for the money or prestige; you're pursuing it because without that degree, you couldn't be you. Examples:



Journalism:
Work for or
start the
school
newspaper



**Applied
Mathematics:**
Become a
Mathlete



**Computer
Science:**
Build an app



Medicine:
Volunteer at
a hospital

Second, the community activity

This extracurricular shows that you give up your time to help the community or people in need. It shows admissions officers you proactively care and want to make changes in the world.

Showing that you can take charge when something concerns you and you're willing to put in the time demonstrates initiative, dedication, and perseverance – all attractive attributes.

Ensure you choose something that is important to you and that you commit enough time to make an impact – at least 12 months or more.

The longer you participate, the more you contribute and your progress will strengthen your application. Working in community service reinforces what you've already learned and develops valuable college-level skills, such as critical thinking and problem solving.

A simple search on Google regarding your interests is the easiest way to get started. Examples:



Animal Shelters –
Love animals
and considering
a career in animal
care



Schools –
Working with children
and teenagers, and
enjoying creativity and
teaching



Hospitals –
To study medicine,
enjoy fast paced
work



Finally, the personal activity

This is the big one, the one that screams your personality and shows the admissions officers what makes you tick. Often, this will be tied to your career or community activity, which means you'll be covered. For example, you want to study medicine so you volunteer at a hospital and at the research lab.

Or, it can completely divert from the narrative in your other activities to give a better picture of you as a whole. For example, you create YouTube videos in your spare time (which you also use as a platform to promote your community activity).

The personal activity has an element of surprise, because it doesn't necessarily align with your other pursuits; rather, it reflects your excitement for life – it should show that you live your life ethically and compassionately. It will show that there's more to you than just study and you're motivated by more than just your future career or field.

The activity cannot be something self-involved, like having 100,000 followers on Instagram.

This extracurricular should either:

1. Continue your personal narrative of ethical community activity, and showcase how your pursuit of your career choice has turned your curiosity into action.
2. Divert to exhibit your uniqueness, your meaningful and sustained contributions, your ability to work with others, and that you work with people from all races.

Examples:



You're a maths whiz, but you also dance competitively in a different cultural scenario to your own.



You're passionate about economics, but you also teach poor kids to free dive.



You plan to become a lawyer – but you have also built your own video game.



You're passionate about the English language, and you've started to teach people English as a second language for free.

Let's consider Student A

Here is an example of one student's extracurricular activities that they put on an application.

Community Activity – I speak English as a second language and tutor others in English to improve their confidence and their ability to find opportunities in the English speaking world.

Career / Personal Activity – Built a prototype mobile app (because I want to study computer science). This app connects people to 'on-call' psychologists (I want to improve the community's mental health, which affects my close personal friends).

This candidate has shown:

- **Passion for using their talent to improve their community's mental health**
- **Initiative in tutoring others in English**
- **Empathy for those who suffer from mental illness**



They are proactively improving their community through their passions, contributions and empathy. Notice the clear, consistent, personal narrative and how the extracurriculars all work together. Also, notice the 'less-is-more' approach with extracurriculars.

This candidate is likely to be considered by many top colleges.

What makes your extracurriculars special?

Are you worried about your extracurriculars and whether they're telling your personal story?

Here are the key qualities that make extracurriculars effective. They can be any hobby or activity as long as they show these qualities.

Quality	Shows
Practicing a hobby or activity for several years	Commitment, passion
Taking the initiative, getting things done	Leadership, gets results
Increasing your responsibility, expanding your role	Work ethic, passion, initiative
Mentoring other people	Positivity, you have peer respect, you can foster relationships
Making something from scratch	Entrepreneurial spirit, self-starter, leadership

The Stuff You Really Need To Know

- Extracurriculars show your personal narrative: what drives you and what you want to change in the world. Use the personal narrative to show you're having an impact on the world and that you live your day-to-day life in an ethical manner.
- Your activities can be anything, but they should reflect the Key Qualities listed in the table above.

Step Four

Leadership: Institutionalised vs Innovative

Now, let's talk a little bit about leadership

There are two main types of leadership that admissions officers look for: institutional leadership and innovative leadership.

Institutional leadership is working within an established structure. Most leadership positions available to students are in a school or club. Some examples include class captain or committee leader, athletic team captains, and managerial roles, such as the president of a book or chess club.

Institutional leadership is a powerful indicator of an ability to work with people as these leadership positions often rely on votes to be elected.

But some students won't succeed at being the captain of an athletic team, a class president, or hold any position that would qualify as 'institutional leadership'.

Fortunately, there is a second type of leadership that universities also value.

Innovative leadership is the act of starting an organization, club, event, or business. This type of leadership shows that a student has the ability to think creatively, strategically, entrepreneurially, and confidently enough to bring ideas into fruition.

Think of leaders like Elon Musk, Mark Zuckerberg, or Steve Jobs, who each founded a revolutionary company by thinking (and leading) outside of the box, in innovative ways. Realistically, this means starting something of your own that hasn't existed before.

While this type of leadership gives a strong boost to applications, students must be able to show examples of what they have achieved, otherwise their hard work may be disregarded.

Being a leader is a great quality, but it needs to be aligned with your personal narrative. To be considered an effective leader you must show a impact on your community and how your work is crossing the boundaries of race, class, and culture – you bring people together.



BERKELEY

How to communicate your extracurriculars on your application

Step One

Building a Personal Brand

The lost art of selling yourself

Have you ever found yourself sitting on a website, your cursor blinking back at you, because you're stuck in a text box – a text box titled 'About Me'? Giving a 30-second about ourselves can be extremely difficult, because we worry about appearing arrogant, boring, or mediocre.

But that's exactly why it's so important. It's the first impression, the first taste of who you are and why people should care. So, what is a personal brand? It's who you are in a nutshell. It succinctly encapsulates your passions and desires, dreams, and goals all in one go. To an admissions officer, it's a leading indicator of who you are and whether your passions and activities will be important contributors to the college.

The scattergun approach is entirely useless to your application

A personal brand helps you communicate your level of "well-lopsidedness" efficiently, which will be vital during your campus visits and admissions officer or alumni interviews.



1. Exploit your interests

What actually gets you off the couch? Are you an aspiring actor? Then get out there and star in a play. Can't stop playing video

games? Start a YouTube channel and use that YouTube channel to do good in the community. Love money? Start your own business with a budget and a business model. Your application will look much stronger if it's supported by your personality.



2. Focus

Quantity does not equal quality. For example, Tesla has made itself into one of the world's most prestigious brands, not because it has brought thousands of products to market

but because it offered something original. The company brought one product to market and perfected it with an unrivalled passion for technology. You need to be your own Elon Musk. Throw yourself into one or two passions and don't spread yourself thin.



3. Admit you're not a superhero

You can't be all things to all people. You can't be the captain of the team, the editor of the paper, the first-chair saxophonist, the champion debater, the world-class baker, the five-star athlete.

You're not a fictional character. You are you. Talk to your close friends about who you are, find out more about yourself and then try to maximize those attributes and make a meaningful contribution to the world.



4. Build your networking skills

The best way for you to practice communicating your personal brand is by being you.

Start with people you already know and chat to them about wanting to push your personal brand more. Then try striking up conversations with people at school or work whom you don't normally talk to, and nurture those fledgling contacts. It is important to extend this to your teachers and your school principal. They can provide valuable recommendations.

As a natural networker, you're more likely to impress the people who matter, like alumni and admissions officers on the interview day.



WARNING

When talking about yourself, try to blend the selling of your attributes with being a natural human being. Over-selling yourself will only detract from your application or interview. Wait for the opportunity to sell yourself, be confident but humble.



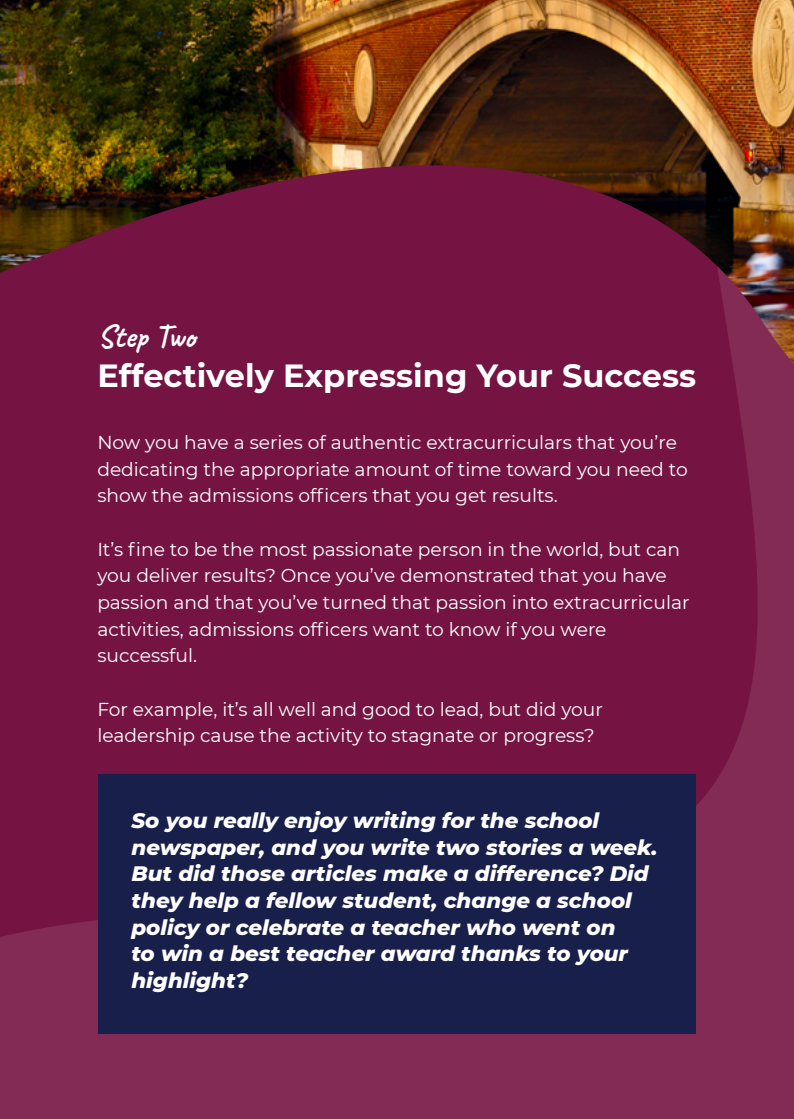


To build a personal brand, you need to:

- Exploit your interests
- Focus your activities
- Admit you're not a superhero
- Network with your peers, teachers, and other influential people

The Stuff You Really Need To Know

You need to sell yourself and you do this by building a personal brand: Something that, on paper, represents who you are succinctly.



Step Two

Effectively Expressing Your Success

Now you have a series of authentic extracurriculars that you're dedicating the appropriate amount of time toward you need to show the admissions officers that you get results.

It's fine to be the most passionate person in the world, but can you deliver results? Once you've demonstrated that you have passion and that you've turned that passion into extracurricular activities, admissions officers want to know if you were successful.

For example, it's all well and good to lead, but did your leadership cause the activity to stagnate or progress?

So you really enjoy writing for the school newspaper, and you write two stories a week. But did those articles make a difference? Did they help a fellow student, change a school policy or celebrate a teacher who went on to win a best teacher award thanks to your highlight?



The key is writing it right

Remember to sell yourself in the activities section of the common app, which goes back to the previous section. Why do you stand out from the crowd? Add adjectives to your skills where possible – but do not lie.

In the descriptions area, make sure you talk about your role in the activity and what you contributed (not about the running history of a club). Keep your writing short, sharp, and punchy. Exclude as

Remember:

- Position description = 50 characters maximum
- Activity description = 150 characters maximum
- Honours title = 100 characters maximum

For example:

Activity type: (Choose relevant drop down)

Position/Leadership description: Founder and president (21 characters)

Describe activity, including accomplishments: Started club, grew membership to 20, organized weekly meetings and hosted tutorial sessions. Organized trip to France to develop students. (136 characters).

General tips

- Emphasise numbers
- Abbreviate, use symbols
- Small phrases
- Do NOT lie
- Re-read, preview, continuously edit
- Link it back to your personal narrative and brand
- Use words that demonstrate your personal brand



The Stuff You Really Need To Know

- Numbers are everything. Data demonstrates success. Include positive statistics in your application wherever possible.
- Write about your role in every activity and include your contribution. Do not get lost writing about anything else.
- Keep it punchy. Revise, revise, revise. Spend a lot of time on this section of your application. It is key.

Now you have a feel for what universities are looking for and how to represent them in your common application.

To get an idea about what it takes to succeed and be offered a spot at one of the colleges, below are a few case studies from some of our successful students.

You can gain insight from their journey and apply the pieces of their information to your own application. Remember, there is no formula! What worked for them is an individual and unique experience to them.





Case Studies

Check out our recent examples of our students and their journey to top universities, using their passions to make an impact and gain entry into the the world's top universities!

[Read Case studies](#)



Summary

Even after all this, don't I still need to be a genius? **The conclusion**

No.

Some schools are always looking for elite academics, but there are thousands of colleges that look for more than just straight A's.

Universities around the world are seeking motivated, passionate students just like you.

You don't need spectacular grades but you do need to be a passionate character, someone who cares about their family and the community, and someone who contributes to society, which is extremely achievable.

While stellar grades always help, colleges also heavily weigh your extracurriculars and how you present yourself beyond the numbers. What are you passionate about? How do you give back to your community? These are the types of questions admissions officers are considering.

If you're unsure of which schools might be a great fit for you or how to make your extracurriculars work for you, contact us for a free consultation.

Talk to us

The impact of COVID-19 on education

This year, the world has been affected by the COVID-19 pandemic, with several countries promoting control and prevention initiatives such as isolation and social distancing, especially the United States. As the virus continues to spread around the world, there is a lot of uncertainty around how it will impact students' academic performance, ability to participate in extracurricular activities, and eventually their college applications.

To stay updated on how COVID-19 is affecting college applications, here are a few resources that will be useful.



Crimson's COVID-19 Support Page

In response to the ongoing crisis, we have compiled a toolbox of resources and information to help keep our community well-informed. The following page includes:

- Relevant and up-to-date news on how COVID-19 is affecting the academic sphere
- Blogs curated by our team to provide tips and tricks as to how to cope with these changes and up your game, despite current challenges
- Links to our webinars which provide further information and advice as to what you can do to make the most of academic and extracurricular opportunities during COVID-19

[Go to page](#)

Guide on online extracurricular activities for High School students



This guide will help you keep your extracurricular engagement strong by helping you brainstorm several activities and initiatives you can do online (or how to move them online). This way, you can still show universities that you are a well-versed student, even in such a hard time.

[Get guide](#)



What is Crimson?

Crimson Education was founded to supercharge students' ability to get accepted into the world's most competitive universities. We now operate in 20 countries and embody the ethical and social responsibility of the International and National Associations of College Admissions Counseling (IACAC & NACAC).

Since 2013, Crimson students around the world have gained admittance to some of the world's leading institutions, but more importantly, to their best-fit universities.

We pride ourselves on the quality and discipline of our advisors and tutors. They are handpicked for their excellent academic achievements and commitment to student success. The Crimson network is expansive with more than 2,400 global tutors and mentors with proven results.



Our Results

99%

of Crimson students accepted into at least 1 of their top 8 universities.

1400+

offers to the top10 US colleges.

268

Ivy League Offers.

99

Acceptances to Oxford & Cambridge

3-5 x

more likely to get into your dream university.



Acceptance Rates

At Crimson, we measure our success by that of our hardworking students and their acceptances into not only the world's best universities, but the school of their dreams. We seek to teach Crimson students the skills

they need in life and don't just measure by admissions. Students who joined Crimson for at least 2 years prior to the university application deadline, were almost 4x as likely to gain admission into the Ivy League than a general

University	General Population Admission Rate	Crimson Student Admission Rate
Harvard	4.5%	12.0%
Stanford	4.3%	17.7%
MIT	6.6%	12.0%
Yale	5.9%	13.9%
Columbia	5.1%	14.0%
The University of Pennsylvania	7.4%	23.0%
Brown	6.6%	31.7%
The University of Chicago	5.9%	25.7%
UC Berkeley	15.0%	28.4%
UCLA	14.1%	29.1%
Duke	8.7%	36.4%
Northwestern	8.9%	25.6%
Oxford	18.9%	35.0%

student. Our results also include students being admitted into specialty programs such as BS/MD, engineering and business schools, merit scholarships, and more. These are just a small sample of

some of the more competitive universities our students have gained acceptance to. We work with students on applying to any schools that fits their goals and have seen the same success across the board.

University	General Population Admission Rate	Crimson Student Admission Rate
Cambridge	24.8%	64.7%
George Washington University	50.3%	72.3%
Tulane University	17%	73%
University of Michigan - Ann Arbor	23%	56.3%
Boston University	22%	67.3%
University of Wisconsin - Madison	52%	81.6%
Syracuse University	50%	100%
University of Texas - Austin	39%	50.6%
Tufts University	15%	46.6%
Boston College	28%	72.3%
University of Southern California	13%	32%
University of Notre Dame	18%	36%
University of North Carolina	22%	88.7%

* This is inclusive of non-California residents, percentages for residents are typically higher.

Why Crimson?

When working with Crimson, our approach is simple. We help students gain admission to the best universities around the world by building personalized and strategic roadmaps based on each student's academic ambitions. We do so through hands-on mentoring and one-on-one support every step of the way.

Our 1:1 support is based on three main points:



PERSONALIZED SUPPORT



TOP SCHOOL MENTORS



CUTTING-EDGE RESOURCES

Our personalized support

We understand each student is unique. Our methodology is focused on analyzing students' goals, strengths and weaknesses to create a program that will help them to achieve results to their best-fit universities.



01

Discover your educational goals

The most important thing to remember is that the initial conversation is a two way street! While your academic advisor is there to understand your academic goals and aspirations, you can ask as many questions as you like in return!

Once the advisor has a good idea of details such as your age, current academic situation and extracurricular passions, they can then make recommendations as to the next steps in your Crimson journey.





*You
alone*

When you're happy with your program decision, your journey to get accepted at top schools begins!



*You with
Crimson*

03

Generate your unique game plan

At Crimson we do not believe in the adage that 'one size fits all'! In fact, a personalized program tailored to individual strengths and weaknesses is built for every single Crimson student.

Once your advisor gains understanding of your academic and extracurricular background, they will make recommendations on the next steps in your Crimson journey and create a custom-built program that fits your needs and aspirations. Each Crimson student's journey looks vastly different.

02

Identify your strengths and weaknesses

Now that we've discussed your goals and aspirations, it's time to evaluate your odds of admission to your university choices.

Based on your profile, your academic advisor will put together a personalized program tailored to your individual strengths and weaknesses.



Our Services



Admissions Strategy

Create a plan and strategy for admissions success with a polished, compelling application showcasing the best version of yourself.



Essay Support

Write essays that stand out to admissions officers. We support and challenge students as they structure, develop and write highly-engaging essays in their own voice with a focused narrative.



Standardized Test Tutoring

Prepare for tests like the SAT, ACT, SAT IIs, and other curriculum like AP/IB with a tutoring plan personalized to you and the tests you are taking.



Extracurricular Mentoring

Receive guidance on which extracurricular activities & competitions to join and how to stand out.



Leadership Mentoring

Develop and scale your own passion project to help you showcase leadership skills. Examples have included mobile apps, nonprofits, and more.



Athletic Scholarship Support

Connect with head coaches, create highlight videos, and receive advice from former student-athletes.



University Selection

Strategically decide your reach, match and safety colleges to fit your interests and academic ability.



Internships & Research

Work with expert career advisors on internship placement and study with researchers at top universities with the Crimson Research Institute.



Top school mentors

We pride ourselves on the quality and discipline of our advisors and tutors. They are handpicked for their excellent academic achievements and commitment to student success. The Crimson network is expansive with more than 2,400 global tutors and mentors with proven results.



Examples of Crimson's mentors:



MEGAN S.

Megan is one of Crimson's most respected strategists, providing guidance to US-bound applicants based around the globe. She has a BA in History and African American Studies from Princeton University and a Masters in Education from Columbia.



GEORGE B.

George received a Bachelor of Arts from Harvard and has helped dozens of Crimson students gain admission into many top US and UK universities, including Oxford and Cambridge.



BOB F.

Bob earned a Bachelor of Science, Cellular and Molecular Biology from Michigan. He's responsible for leading the strategy team and has delivered results to more than 200+ students working with Crimson.



CAROLINA L.

Carolina graduated from Duke University with a double major in Psychology and French and a Minor in Education. She has worked with over 300 students individually and has led workshops to another 400. Her students have been accepted to Ivy League schools, Stanford and her alma mater, Duke.



Cutting-edge resources

Crimson offers high-technology resources to help our students to get to their next level.

Crimson App

Crimson App is an online learning management platform, connecting you directly with your tutors, mentors and strategists. Students book sessions, organize application sections, and can view a customized roadmap of upcoming tasks.

Crimson Calculators

The Crimson Calculators provides you with access to find the US or UK university that best suits you. Enter your SAT score and other details into these calculators to generate a list of recommended universities that are the best fit for you.



Crimson ECL

Search through thousands of extracurricular opportunities from top companies around the world, and students looking for participants in leadership initiatives, all curated by our experts.

Personality Test

We utilize psychometrics to pair each student with a team that is optimized to their interests and learning style! Our test was developed from one of the most well-known data scientists in the world, Galen Buckwalter.



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